

FILM DOSSIER: IRON MAN

Phase 1 · Film #1 · The film that starts everything

Status:  DOSSIER COMPLETE (awaiting showrunner lock)

1. IDENTITY

Field	Entry
Film #	1 of 29 (Infinity Saga)
Phase	Phase 1 (2008–2012)
Real title	<i>IRON MAN</i>
Decoy / codename title	" <i>DESERT ROSE</i> " on call sheets, permits and the Lone Pine and Long Island location signage
Release date	Friday, May 2, 2008
Distributor	Paramount Pictures
Director	Jon Favreau
Writers	Mark Fergus & Hawk Ostby, Art Marcum & Matt Holloway
Rating / runtime	PG-13 (sequences of intense sci-fi action and violence, and brief suggestive content) · 148 minutes
Genre + second genre	Superhero action-adventure + techno-thriller / military-industrial drama
Budget	\$140 million

2. OWNERSHIP

Field	Entry
Whose film / franchise is this?	MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK. The Iron Man franchise is his.
Top-billed cast	see below

Character	Actor	Born	Age at release (May 2, 2008)
Tony Stark / Iron Man	Marc-Anthony Bullock	Jan 5, 1982	26
Virginia "Pepper" Potts	Tayia Boyd	Feb 3, 1982	26
Lt. Col. James "Rhodey" Rhodes	Don Cheadle	Nov 29, 1964	43
Obadiah Stane / Iron Monger	Jeff Bridges	Dec 4, 1949	58
Harold "Happy" Hogan	Jon Favreau	Oct 19, 1966	41
Professor Ho Yinsen	Shaun Toub	Dec 15, 1963	44
Wong-Chu	Tzi Ma	June 10, 1962	45
Agent Jasper Sitwell (S.H.I.E.L.D.)	Maximiliano Hernández	Nov 12, 1973	34
Nick Fury (<i>post-credit</i>)	Samuel L. Jackson	Dec 21, 1948	59
Janet van Dyne (<i>cameo</i>)	Elxa Bullock (<i>secret cameo, uncredited until Comic-Con, July 2008</i>)	Aug 29, 1980	27
Mistress Death (<i>uncredited; silent at Yinsen's death</i>)	Aubrey Plaza	June 26, 1984	23
Stan Lee (<i>cameo, mistaken for Hugh Hefner at the gala</i>)	Stan Lee	Dec 28, 1922	85

Casting note: Wong-Chu has never been played by a real-life actor, so this is an original casting of a real actor. Everyone else follows the Casting Rules.

3. SOURCE MATERIAL (EARTH-616)

Field	Entry
Primary comic(s) adapted	<i>Tales of Suspense</i> #39 (March 1963): the origin, by Stan Lee, Larry Lieber, Don Heck & Jack Kirby. <i>Iron Man</i> #163–200 (1982–1985): Obadiah Stane's war on Tony Stark, ending in the Iron Monger battle, by Denny O'Neil & Luke McDonnell.
Supporting comics	<i>Tales of Suspense</i> #40 (1963, the gold armor) · #45 (1963, first Pepper Potts & Happy Hogan) · #48 (1963, the first red-and-gold armor, Steve Ditko) · <i>Iron Man</i> #118 (1979, first Jim Rhodes) · <i>Iron Man</i> #144 (1981, how Rhodey met Tony in the war zone) · <i>Iron Man</i> vol. 3 #55 (2002, Tony publicly reveals he's Iron Man) · <i>Iron Man: Extremis</i> (2005–06, Warren Ellis & Adi Granov, the modern origin moved to Afghanistan)
616 accuracy notes	See Section 3A
Nerf check	✓ Every armor, hero and villain appears at the power level the comics give that specific armor model. See the powers table.

3A. COMIC ACCURACY REPORT

Field	Entry
Overall accuracy score	96% . The origin, armor progression, supporting cast, villains and the Stane arc all come straight from 616. The only changes are sliding-timescale updates and compressing a three-year comic arc into one film.

Straight from the page:

- **The origin:** Tony, a weapons-industry genius, is wounded by a booby trap with **shrapnel lodged near his heart**. He's captured by the warlord **Wong-Chu** and forced to build weapons, and with the Nobel-nominated physicist **Ho Yinsen** he builds the **Mark I** instead. **Yinsen sacrifices himself** to buy Tony time.
- **The chest plate:** the armor's **chest plate is what keeps Tony's heart beating**. It has to be **recharged**, and yes, **Tony plugs himself into a wall socket** in one scene, straight out of the Silver Age.
- **The armor progression, exactly as in the comics:** **gray Mark I** (*ToS* #39) → **gold Mark II** (*ToS* #40, "the Golden Avenger") → **red-and-gold Mark III** (*ToS* #48).
- **Rhodey** is a **Marine Corps aviator** (as in 616) who picks Tony up after the escape (*Iron Man* #144).
- **Happy Hogan** is a **former boxer** turned Tony's driver and bodyguard (*ToS* #45).
- **Pepper Potts** is Tony's sharp, capable executive assistant (*ToS* #45).
- **Obadiah Stane** is bald and **obsessed with chess**. He talks about people as pawns, targets Tony through his company, and builds the **Iron Monger** armor from Tony's stolen designs (*Iron Man* #163–200). **He dies by his own hand after he's beaten** (*Iron Man* #200), handled off-screen for PG-13.
- **The "bodyguard" cover story:** Tony first tells the press that Iron Man is his **bodyguard**, the classic 616 secret-identity ruse. Then, following the modern 616 reveal (vol. 3 #55), he tells the world: **"I am Iron Man."**
- **The Maria Stark Foundation**, named for Tony's late mother and the Avengers' future funder in 616, holds its

charity gala.

- **Tony's home is 890 Fifth Avenue, Manhattan**, the Stark family mansion that becomes **Avengers Mansion** in 616.

- **Stark Industries headquarters is on Long Island, New York**, as in 616.

- **Howard and Maria Stark died in a car crash** (616), which put Tony in charge of the company at 21.

Changes and why:

| Change | Why |

|---|---|

| Vietnam → **Afghanistan** | The sliding timescale. Marvel's own *Extremis* (2005) moved the origin to Afghanistan, and we follow the latest 616 version. |

| The Stane arc (1982–85) is compressed into one film | Runtime. The beats (takeover, chess games, stolen armor tech, Iron Monger, suicide) stay the same, but Tony's slide back into alcoholism is **saved for Iron Man 2** so it gets the time it needs. |

| Mark I built in a **cave** instead of a jungle hut | Follows the Afghanistan update. |

| Mark I gets an improvised flamethrower and a short rocket hop | Derived from later 616 armor tech so the escape is believable. It's listed here to be transparent. |

| Tony's in-universe age is **26** (b. May 29, 1981) | This matches Marc-Anthony. 616 Tony's age slides; ours follows the actor per the real-time rule. |

| Casting of Pepper, Happy, Yinsen and others | Follows the Casting Rules. The characters' histories and personalities are unchanged. |

POWERS & ABILITIES: CHARACTER BY CHARACTER

Character	616 powers & abilities (source)	Shown in this film	Held back (and why)	Power-level match
Tony Stark (unarmored)	Super-genius inventor and engineer; expert businessman; skilled hand-to-hand fighter (trained by Happy/Cap in later issues) (<i>ToS</i> #39 on)	Builds a working armor from scraps in a cave. Designs the Mk II and Mk III. Out-thinks Stane in business and in combat.	Hand-to-hand training (it comes later in the comics too)	✓ 100%
Mark I (gray)	Transistor-boosted superhuman strength ; heavy steel plating that stops small-arms fire; reverse-magnetism effects (<i>ToS</i> #39)	Tears through a steel cave door; bullets bounce off; flings Wong-Chu's men across the cave	Sustained flight (Mk I couldn't fly on 616 either)	✓ 100%
Mark II (gold)	Lighter gold armor; jet boot flight ; boosted strength (<i>ToS</i> #40)	First real flight, the famous "clean slate" test over Long Island Sound	Advanced weapons (added in later models)	✓ 100%
Mark III (red & gold)	Sleeker armor; repulsor rays in the palms; uni-beam in the chest; supersonic flight; multi-ton strength ; sensors and radar (<i>ToS</i> #48 on)	Repulsors, uni-beam, supersonic flight, lifting a car full of civilians clear of a collapsing overpass, blocking tank rounds	The later 100-ton-class models and Extremis (these come as the armors advance in later films, as in the comics)	✓ 100% for this model
Iron Monger (Stane)	Massive armor built from stolen Stark tech. Stronger and more heavily armored than Tony's current suit , with a heavy arsenal (<i>Iron Man</i> #200)	Outmuscles the Mark III. Tony wins by out-thinking him by cutting his power and using his size against him, not by suddenly being stronger.	–	✓ 100% (Stane loses on strategy, not because he was weakened)
Obadiah Stane (unarmored)	Master manipulator and chess strategist; ruthless businessman (<i>Iron Man</i> #163)	The hostile takeover of Stark Industries; the arms deals with Wong-Chu	–	✓ 100%
Wong-Chu	Ruthless warlord; skilled military commander (<i>ToS</i> #39)	Captures and tortures Tony, commands an army	–	✓ 100%
Ho Yinsen	Nobel-nominated physicist and engineer (<i>ToS</i> #39)	Co-builds the Mk I and the chest plate	–	✓ 100%
James Rhodes	Elite Marine combat pilot; skilled soldier (<i>Iron Man</i> #118)	Pilots the rescue helicopter; flies combat support during the finale	Wearing the armor himself (<i>Iron Man</i> #169, 1983). Saved	✓ 100%

Character	616 powers & abilities (source)	Shown in this film	Held back (and why)	Power-level match
			for <i>Iron Man 2</i> to line up with the drinking arc, as in the comics.	
Happy Hogan	Former professional boxer (ToS #45)	Knocks out two of Stane's security guards	–	✓ 100%
Pepper Potts	Brilliant executive; resourceful and courageous (ToS #45)	Runs Stark Industries while Tony's captive; steals the evidence against Stane	Rescue armor (616, much later). It's her future, not a nerf.	✓ 100%
Nick Fury	Infinity Formula (slowed aging); master spy and strategist; WWII veteran (Sgt. Fury #1, 1963)	Walks through Tony's security like it isn't there	Full history (shown in Captain America's film)	✓ 100%

4. STORY

Field	Entry
Logline	A weapons-industry genius is captured by the warlord using his own weapons. He builds a suit of armor to escape, and comes home determined to fix what he helped break, unaware that the most dangerous man in his life is sitting across the chessboard.
Theme	Responsibility. Tony built weapons without caring where they ended up. Iron Man is how he makes up for it.

What the movie is about

ACT ONE: THE CAVE

- **Kunar Province, Afghanistan.** **Tony Stark** (26), the playboy genius who has run **Stark Industries** since his parents died, is demonstrating a new transistor-guided weapons system for U.S. forces.
- His convoy is ambushed. A booby-trapped Stark shell explodes and **shrapnel lodges near his heart**.
- He wakes up in a cave, prisoner of the warlord **Wong-Chu**. Wong-Chu's men are carrying **Stark weapons**. Somebody sold them.
- **Ho Yinsen**, a Nobel-nominated physicist and fellow prisoner, has kept Tony alive with a **chest plate** that keeps the shrapnel from reaching his heart.
- Wong-Chu orders them to build him a weapon. Instead, they build the **Mark I**.
- The escape. **Yinsen sacrifices himself** to buy Tony time. As he dies, only the audience sees **a pale woman in a dark hooded cloak** standing silently at the cave mouth. Then she's gone.

- Tony tears through the cave and burns the stockpile of Stark weapons. Wong-Chu escapes.
- **Marine aviator James Rhodes** picks him up in the desert, and a friendship begins.

ACT TWO: THE GOLDEN AVENGER

- Back in New York, Tony announces that **Stark Industries will stop making weapons**. The stock collapses.
- **Obadiah Stane**, head of **Stane International** and a longtime "family friend," starts moving pieces around the board.
- In the workshop under his **Fifth Avenue mansion**, Tony builds the **gold Mark II** and makes his first flight over Long Island Sound.
- The **Maria Stark Foundation** gala: Tony meets **Pepper** on the dance floor, and Stan Lee is mistaken for Hugh Hefner.
- Tony finds out that **Stark weapons are still reaching Wong-Chu**.
- He builds the **red-and-gold Mark III** and flies to Afghanistan to wipe out the arms stockpile. Wong-Chu's forces are shattered.
- The press notices a "flying metal man." Tony's cover story is that it's **his bodyguard**.
- A S.H.I.E.L.D. agent, **Jasper Sitwell**, keeps trying to book a debriefing. Tony keeps not showing up.

ACT THREE: CHECKMATE

- Pepper gets into Stark Industries' servers and finds that **Stane has been selling weapons to Wong-Chu and ordered the ambush on Tony's convoy**.
- Stane has launched a **hostile takeover** of Stark Industries and has reverse-engineered the Mark I from the wreckage his contacts recovered.
- He ambushes Tony at home and **rips the chest plate out** ("Every king falls, Tony. It's just a matter of moves"), leaving him to die.
- Tony survives by crawling to the **wall socket** and plugging in the old Mark I chest plate that Pepper had framed.
- The finale runs across Long Island: **Iron Monger vs. Iron Man**. Stane is stronger. **Tony wins by out-thinking him**. He lures Iron Monger into the facility's power grid and overloads it.
- Beaten and unmasked, **Stane takes his own life** (off-screen) rather than be arrested.
- The press conference. Pepper hands Tony the **bodyguard story** on note cards. He looks at them, puts them down, and says:

"The truth is... I am Iron Man."

5. MCU TIMELINE PLACEMENT

Field	Entry
When it's set	Tuesday, January 8, 2008 (the ambush) → Friday, April 25, 2008 (the press conference). The post-credit scene takes place Saturday, April 26, 2008 . Tony is in captivity for about three months (January–March 2008).
Where it's set	Kunar Province, Afghanistan (filmed in Lone Pine, CA) · Stark Industries HQ, Long Island, NY · Tony's mansion, 890 Fifth Avenue, Manhattan (future Avengers Mansion) · Long Island Sound · Washington, D.C. (a Senate hearing Tony skips)
Relative to other films	The first chronological event of the modern MCU. It ends a few weeks before <i>The Incredible Hulk</i> (Film #2), and the two overlap: the gamma incident is on the news in Tony's workshop.

Stark family timeline (canon):

| Event | Date |

---|---

| Tony Stark born | May 29, 1981 |

| Howard & Maria Stark die in a car crash | December 16, 2002 (Tony is 21 and takes over Stark Industries) |

| The ambush in Kunar | January 8, 2008 |

| "I am Iron Man" | April 25, 2008 |

6. WORLD-BUILDING

The film's own world

- **Stark Industries** on Long Island, **Stane International** as its rival, and Tony's **Fifth Avenue mansion** with the workshop underneath.
- **The armor progression** (gray → gold → red and gold), the **chest plate** and its recharging problem, **repulsors** and the **uni-beam**.
- **The supporting cast:** Pepper, Happy, Rhodey, Yinsen's legacy, Stane.
- **The Maria Stark Foundation**, the Stark family's charity.
- **The rules:** Iron Man is **technology, not magic**. Anything the armor does has to be something Tony could build.

World-building for the wider MCU

Seed	How it appears	Payoff
S.H.I.E.L.D.	Agent Jasper Sitwell keeps trying to debrief Tony. The acronym is said once in full: <i>Strategic Hazard Intervention Espionage Logistics Directorate</i> .	The post-credit scene, and every Phase 1 film
The Hulk	A TV in Tony's workshop plays a news report: "...an accident at the Army's gamma test site at Desert Base, New Mexico... General Thaddeus Ross declined to comment..."	The Incredible Hulk (Film #2)
Hank Pym / Ant-Man	Tony tosses a science journal onto his workbench. The cover story is Dr. Henry Pym, "Pym Particles: Shrinking the Future." Tony mutters: <i>"Show-off."</i>	<i>Ant-Man and the Wasp</i>
Janet van Dyne / The Wasp	At the Maria Stark Foundation gala, a fashion designer in a black-and-yellow gown teases Tony about his tuxedo. Pepper introduces her as "Janet van Dyne, the designer."	<i>Ant-Man and the Wasp / The Avengers</i>
The Mandarin	The mid-credit scene (see Section 7)	<i>Iron Man 2</i>
Rhodey in armor	Rhodey looks at the empty Mark II and says, <i>"Next time, baby."</i>	<i>Iron Man 2</i> (616: <i>Iron Man</i> #169)
Avengers Mansion	Tony's Fifth Avenue home is shown at length: the grand hall, the stairs, the portrait of Howard and Maria	<i>The Avengers</i> (Tony hands it over to the team, as in 616)
"The Avengers"	Said for the first time by Nick Fury in the post-credit scene	<i>The Avengers</i> (Film #8)

Setting up the Big Bad (Thanos / the Infinity Saga)

The setup is deliberately hidden. A general audience won't catch it, but the comic fans will.

Seed	How it appears	What it means
Mistress Death	When Yinsen dies , only the audience sees a pale woman in a dark hooded cloak at the cave mouth, silent. She looks at Yinsen, then at Tony. Then she's gone. No music sting and no explanation.	Thanos's beloved. She's the reason for the whole saga, she visits the dying, and she has already noticed Tony Stark.
Titan	In the workshop, a Stark satellite feed Tony hacked flags an anomaly: <i>"Unidentified object departing orbit of Titan, Saturn's sixth moon."</i> Tony closes the window: <i>"Not my problem."</i>	Thanos's home. A Titan-launched ship is on the move.
Iron Man #55	Easter egg: the Stark Industries press-conference podium is numbered "55"	Thanos's first appearance was in <i>Iron Man</i> #55 (1973), a note for the fans.

7. POST-CREDIT SCENES

Field	Entry
Mid-credit scene	✓ YES: "THE RINGS." A mountain fortress somewhere in China. A battered Wong-Chu kneels and presents a crate holding the wreckage of the Mark I helmet. A hand reaches in. It wears ten rings, each one different, all clearly not of this Earth. A calm voice: <i>"The iron man."</i> CUT TO BLACK. <i>(The Mandarin, voice only, for Iron Man 2.)</i>
Post-credit scene	✓ YES: "THE INITIATIVE." Tony's Fifth Avenue mansion, night. Tony walks in and finds someone standing by the window in the dark: Nick Fury. Eye patch. Long coat. Cigar. FURY: <i>"'I am Iron Man.' You think you're the only superhero in the world, Mr. Stark?"</i> (beat) <i>"You've gotten yourself into something much bigger than your company. I'm here to talk to you about the Avengers Initiative."</i> CUT TO BLACK. "IRON MAN WILL RETURN."
Secret shoot codenames	Post-credit: "RHODEY'S BIRTHDAY PARTY" (a skeleton crew of 12, sides collected after every take). Mid-credit: "GRANDPA'S JEWELRY BOX."

8. ★ FIRST FILM ONLY: HOW IT KICKS EVERYTHING OFF

Field	Entry
How the film launches the shared universe	<i>Iron Man</i> works entirely as a standalone film, and it quietly builds the foundation for everything after it. It establishes S.H.I.E.L.D. as the thread that runs through every later film. It establishes a public superhero ("I am Iron Man"), which puts heroes in the open for the rest of the saga. It gives the future Avengers a home (890 Fifth Avenue) and a source of money (Stark and the Maria Stark Foundation). And it opens a door to other films through the Desert Base news report and the Pym journal.
The first reveal	The post-credit scene. Most of the audience will have walked out and the ushers will be sweeping popcorn. The people who stay see Nick Fury in Tony's living room say the word "Avengers." That's the moment the world gets bigger.
What the fans discover, and when	Opening night (Thursday May 1 at midnight, and Friday May 2): shaky camera-phone video of the post-credit scene is on YouTube within hours. By Saturday, message boards are breaking down every Easter egg: Desert Base, the Pym journal, Titan, podium 55. By Monday, May 5, AICN and SuperHeroHype have threads titled <i>"ARE THE MARVEL MOVIES CONNECTED??"</i> Marvel says nothing.
The unexplained seed	The hooded woman at Yinsen's death. Nobody officially notices her for years. Some fans see her and argue about her on forums, and she's dismissed as an extra, a mistake, or Yinsen's wife. She's the saga's quietest and most important seed.

Seeds planted for Phase 1

Seed	Pays off in
S.H.I.E.L.D. / Jasper Sitwell	Every Phase 1 film
Desert Base gamma accident, General Ross	<i>The Incredible Hulk</i> (Film #2, Friday June 13, 2008)
The Pym journal ("Pym Particles")	<i>Ant-Man and the Wasp</i> (Film #4, Nov 6, 2009)
Janet van Dyne at the gala	<i>Ant-Man and the Wasp</i> (Film #4) / <i>The Avengers</i>
The Mandarin and the ten rings	<i>Iron Man 2</i> (Film #5, May 7, 2010)
"Next time, baby" (Rhodey's armor)	<i>Iron Man 2</i> (Film #5)
Fury and "the Avengers Initiative"	<i>The Avengers</i> (Film #8)
890 Fifth Avenue becomes Avengers Mansion	<i>The Avengers</i>
The Titan anomaly	Phase 1 finale / <i>The Avengers</i> post-credit (Thanos)
The hooded woman (Death)	The whole Infinity Saga

CHECKLIST

- [x] Comic(s) adapted
- [x] Comic Accuracy Report, including powers for every character
- [x] Real title and decoy title
- [x] What the movie is about
- [x] Villain / antagonist
- [x] Post-credit scene(s)
- [x] The film's own world-building
- [x] MCU world-building
- [x] Big Bad setup
- [x] Whose film / franchise it is
- [x] When and where it's set in the MCU timeline
- [x] **First film only:** how it kicks everything off